

From Myth to History

As Greece emerged from a “Dark Age” and writing was rediscovered, new ways of passing on knowledge and stories developed. For the first time in the Western world, history was recorded in prose, rather than verse—the poet became a historian and artistic license gave way to the goal of accuracy and explanation.

During excavations at the Palace of Knossos on the island of Crete in 1900, the British archaeologist Arthur Evans found a huge collection of written clay tablets. They had survived a fire that destroyed the palace some time after 1400 BCE. When the script, known as “Linear B,” was deciphered, it turned out to be the first known example of early Greek writing. The art of writing then seems to have been lost to the Greeks during the so-called “Dark Age” (c. 1100–c. 750 BCE).

The subsequent development of the Greek alphabet and writing led to the recording of history. Before the 6th century BCE, history was

recounted in the form of poetry and was mixed with folklore and myth, making it hard to separate fact from fiction.

Ancient Greece’s most famous poet, Homer, (see below) is an important

Trojan hero Hector. Schliemann’s archaeological practices destroyed a great deal of the value of the site. Later experts were appalled at what he had done and even questioned the

authenticity of the many gold artifacts he claimed to have found. Schliemann went on to find more treasures at Mycenae on the Greek mainland, including the mask (see right) that he

Odysseus’s voyage

This 3rd-century-CE Roman mosaic shows Homer’s Odysseus on his epic journey. In this part of the story he is lured onto a rocky island by the singing of the Sirens.



figure in the transmission of history in the Western world, although he probably never wrote down his own poems, and the subjects he used were a mixture of myth, folk memory, and fact. The story of the Trojan War, which may have been an actual event of the 13th century BCE, inspired both his epic poems, the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey*. In the first of these, two intense weeks in the story of the war are told. The *Odyssey* tells the tale of the Greek hero Odysseus’s ten-year journey home from the Trojan War. Both stories show a desire to keep alive memory of past glories and hinge on Greek memories of an expedition to Troy in Asia Minor (Turkey). The actual events, if they happened at all, were not recorded in any surviving written accounts. This meant that over the intervening centuries, the facts were mingled with myth and travelers’ tales to become the story we know today.

declared to be one of the leaders of the Greek siege of Troy, saying, “I have gazed into the face of Agamemnon.” It is probable that it was in fact part of a royal burial treasure from a period before the Trojan War.

First written history

An early Greek writer to break away from this mix of myth and reality was Hecataeus of Miletus (c. 550–490 BCE), who is considered by some to be the first history writer. In one of his works, he set down in writing stories that had been passed down orally from generation to generation as well as

recording family genealogies. Another writer, Simonides (c. 556–469 BCE), referred to events of the

Persian invasion of 480 BCE in his poems.

It is a later writer, however, who is known today as the “father of history.” Herodotus (484–425 BCE) wrote *The Histories*, which focused on the origins of the war between Greece and Persia that took place at the beginning of the 5th century BCE. He was interested in studying human nature and the world around him and recorded what he saw as he traveled the length and breadth of the ancient world. Although he came from Halicarnassus (modern Bodrum in Turkey), he also lived in Athens for a time. His travels allegedly took him to Egypt, Italy, Sicily, and Babylon, and his writing is full of entertaining detail about the customs and habits of the countries he visited.

Herodotus is remembered today because he was the first to write about events of his own time in prose rather than verse, and to organize his material systematically. He inspired later historians to break with the old epic tradition and write in this style, recounting real events rather than the mythical exploits of heroes and gods.

The work of Herodotus cannot, however, be relied upon as fact. His writing still depended, to some extent, on oral history and was colored by folklore and tradition. He claimed to have authenticated his information, but critics in antiquity argued that it was not wholly accurate. The later Greek historian and biographer Plutarch (c. 46–119 CE) had a very low opinion

BEFORE

Epic narratives often lie between myth and history. Such poetry was born out of an oral tradition and was common in many ancient cultures before written history.

URUK

The epic (long narrative poem) of *Gilgamesh* is the story of a semidivine king of Uruk << 44 that was told by storytellers in the 3rd millennium BCE. Some parts of the story are **fantastical** and others may be based on **real events**.

ANCIENT BABYLON

Scribes in Babylon << 55, 79, 90 recorded events relating to the **history of their city** from the 2nd millennium BCE. The records contained references to earlier semilegendary times and were a mixture of fact and fiction.



SCENE FROM THE EPIC OF GILGAMESH

Fantasy and fact

One 19th-century archaeologist, Heinrich Schliemann, became obsessed with the story of the Trojan War and was determined to find evidence that it had actually taken place. Using the text of the *Iliad* as a guide, Schliemann found a vast city complex buried under various layers at Hissalik in northwest Turkey. One layer of the city had been destroyed by fire c. 1180 BCE. He was convinced that this was Troy, where the mythical Achilles had killed the

GREEK POET (c. 8TH CENTURY BCE)

HOMER

There is no firm evidence about the life of the most famous Greek epic poet. He is believed to have lived in Greece in the 8th or 7th century BCE, but we do not know what he looked like or where he originally came from. Traditionally, he is said to have been blind and to have told his stories as he traveled around Greece. His two great works, the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey*, began life as epic poetry, recited aloud to audiences. Only later were they written down. Homer is still considered one of the most influential writers of the Western world.

